

INTRODUCTION

The scenario involves Charlie, a child aged three years old. He begins display many behaviours associated with autism. He progresses through from Kindergarten to Primary school. This study will discuss autism in the context of how its definition has altered over the decades. It will investigate the different successes and challenges Charlie faces due to his autism within his education and home environments. It will discuss the various types of strategies and support needs that are available for Charlie at home and school. It will analyse the team approach that is recommended for early interventions in a child's life, along with how assessment takes place. The child's parents as carers will also be considered.

Signs of autism

There are many different signs of autism that can be displayed by an individual. Many symptoms include problems with eye contact, social interaction difficulties and speech issues as shown in Charlie's situation (Silberman 2001; Nall 2018; Ozonoff et al 2008; Ronski 2015). Silberman (2001) Psychologist Attwood, describes children who lack basic social and motor skills, who are unable to decode body language and sense the feelings of others, they avoid eye contact and often speak in monologues about their interests. Autism is a developmental disability affecting every aspect of a child's development in areas such as social development, behaviour and communication (Raising Children 2017; Autism Spectrum 2019; Melbourne Paediatrics' 2019). These sources refer to the same areas as being assessed for a diagnosis of ASD. Autism can be seen as "trapped inside oneself" (Autism Spectrum Australia 2012).

Early Intervention

If a child receives early intervention early on in their lives then this will produce maximum results for the future of the child and limit strain on the individual's family (Ronski 2015; Autism Spectrum Australia 2019). Early diagnosis for a child is generally common during the years of three to four years old and screening is often available (Russell 2012; Autism Spectrum Australia 2019). This Autism Spectrum Australia (2019) refers to diagnosis of ASD as using observations and standard tests and questionnaires. Charlie is three years old therefore this is the common time that he could be diagnosed. Individuals with autism as having repetitive and restricted interests and signs such as these maybe observed Nall (2018). Information is collated in terms of their strengths and difficulties. There are a group of specialists involved such as psychiatrists and psychologists (Melbourne Paediatrics' 2019). DSM V referred to the diagnosis of ASD as having a severity ranking of 1 to 3 dependent upon the persons support needs. The ICD referred to four different categories. When a worthy diagnoses is made during early school years then the evidence indicates that there is a larger chance that there will be an enriched development route. The assessment for autism is a multi-disciplinary process. When autism is assessed it goes through a process of numerous specialists and professionals who make their judgments upon a child collectively and collaboratively (Raising Children 2017; Melbourne Paediatrics 2019). This allows a more accurate diagnoses of a child and results in a more suitable and purposeful intervention plan for the child. The specialists watch a child playing and how they interact with others, they interview the parent and look through the child's past history. The best intervention must be tailored to the needs of the child (Guldborg 2010). The three areas they focus upon is behaviour, communication and social skills of the child (Raising Children 2017; Autism Spectrum 2019; Melbourne Paediatrics' 2019).

A multi-disciplinary approach

A multi-disciplinary approach must be applied with a child with autism. In Melbourne Paediatrics' (2019) this refers to a team of specialists that attempt to collectively decide on an intervention for the child with autism. Once Charlie's parents refer him to a speech and language therapist and an occupational therapist who work as a team. Charlie's behaviour improves which indicates why early intervention is important (Ronski 2015; Autism Spectrum Australia 2019). Melbourne Paediatrics' 2019; Autism Spectrum Australia 2019; Nall 2018 refers to the requirement of a team of specialists such as clinical psychologists, speech therapists, occupational therapists and teachers. The first step is to assess a child if a parent suspects their child has autism, they first refer to a general practitioner and then paediatrician. They then can regularly see the paediatrician, as many families with children with developmental delays find this useful and supportive (Melbourne Paediatrics 2019).

There is a lot of development now for early years support due to an increase in knowledge and therefore strategies to intervene. Technology is developing rapidly and therefore we can use these forms as support for those with autism such as iPads and Proloquo software (Ronski 2015).

Challenges and Strategies

Interests

The speech and occupational therapist implement play based therapy for Charlie Nall (2018) and focus on his interests which is supported in Forbes (2017) which states that many have a hyper interest that they can excel in (Silberman 2001). Raising Children (2017) refers to various interventions available children with autism. A strategy of social skills training in which the child is taught how to acknowledge non-verbal cues that they often have difficulties reading. Many children with autism find making friends difficult (Nall 2018) such as Charlie. Charlie becomes involved in a social skills group and makes progress and begins playing with other children. The programs can be created by a therapist.

Sensory

Charlie is moved to a quieter environment and his behaviours improve. Children with autism often have sensory issues and have difficulties with sounds. Charlie has problems with loud sounds therefore the occupational therapist could provide him with headphones by the occupational therapist to block out too many sounds and distractions as they are often unable to do this themselves (Autism Awareness 2019).

Speech

Charlie has speech difficulties therefore his communication has limitations. A strategy that could be applied by the speech therapist is the use of a form AAC Augmentative and Alternative Communication such as software Proloquo on an iPad for Charlie. He could then communicate with his parents which would support them too (Ronski 2015). Charlie found it difficult to make friends therefore being able to communicate with his parents when he returns home is vital. He suffers from meltdowns at home after he has been to school therefore this may ease the frustration and poor behaviour (Ronski 2015).

Transition

Charlie faces problems with transitioning which is a trait of autism (Hume 2008). He could have a schedule with symbols to show him the routine and when he will be moving so he is prepared for the change rather than it appearing suddenly as those with autism require routine and structure and do not cope with change well (Raising Children 2017). Also anxiety levels must be considered during transitions (Hannah 2012)

Interventions/strategies

Another strategy would be CBT Cognitive behaviour therapy which is linked to how we are feeling and how to then react. CBT also involves discussing feelings with a child, relaxation strategies and this in turn will help the child make friends as in Charlie's case (Raising Children 2017). Another strategy refers to cartooning strategies in which symbols are used to allow children with ASD to understand social environments (Raising Children 2017).

Modelling can be used so that the child then can copy how to act. In Charlie's case this could be put into place when is having a meltdown at home his parents could get him to draw how he is feeling. Peer training is also used when children who developing typically integrate with those with ASD (Raising Children 2017). Charlie could continue to play with his sister as she is neuro-typical therefore she is able to model playing together which would benefit Charlie. Self- management techniques are used to allow a child to maintain their behaviour (Raising Children 2017).

The key issues were that Charlie was struggling in the child care environment. An intervention had to be put into place but only after assessments had been made to determine a suitable intervention plan. The key issues for the carers is that the child centre was making a diagnosis when this was not their place. The initial point of contact should have been the general practitioner (Melbourne Paediatrics 2019; Autism Spectrum Australia 2019). The parents then received support from the SLT and the OT which is vital for everyone to work together to implement any interventions for the child (Melbourne Paediatrics 2019). The guidance is also useful to the parent to also show them that they are not alone as indicated in the (Raising Children 2017) video in which they have many negative feelings about having a child with autism.

Carers

Carers of those with autism have an extensive role and responsibility which impacts them in numerous ways. In the Autism Spectrum Australia (2012) video Mr Warren Senior Consultant, he refers to families with children with autism have a constant job and that it has a huge consequence on the families. Carers are often classed as the experts of their child therefore Charlie's parents should also be involved and included in any interventions for Charlie (Autism Spectrum Australia 2012; Mackin 2013). Raising Children Network (2017) refers to many parents who discuss their feelings of frustration with having children with autism. This can be linked to Charlie's parents who may have experience frustration during his meltdowns when he arrived home after school. Also linked to Charlie's mother who tried to research his symptoms to try to support him. This demonstrates the struggles carers face every day (Raising Children Network 2017; Voices from the spectrum 2017; Autism Spectrum Australia 2012). Carers experience a range of negative emotions this indicates how it is not just about the individual with autism but also about those around them such as their carers and hence the need for

support for this cohort. In Voices from the spectrum (2017) video Mr Plank refers to having meltdowns as a child and how his parents were at a loss of how to discipline him. Support must be given to the carers to ensure that they can also support the individual with autism, but coping within themselves.

Awareness

Awareness over time about autism is becoming much more prominent, understood, accepted and widespread in communities. There are many strategies today that those with autism can utilise and awareness amongst educators and clinicians. There are quicker diagnosis and increase in autism (Autism Spectrum Australia 2012; Silberman 2001).

In Voices from the spectrum (2017) different people discuss their views on their autism. Autism is said to often be viewed as a mental disorder, Ms Dawson discusses the history of autism and how the definition and viewpoint on this condition have altered over the years. Autism was a narrowly defined condition and how this has been eradicated as now there is a broad spectrum that we view autism under such as having difficulties with social interaction or communication and those with autism having repetitive behaviours and certain interests (Voices from the spectrum 2017; Autism Spectrum Australia 2019). This demonstrates that the views upon autism are constantly changing and the increasing amount of support available for carers and individuals with autism.

Silberman (2001) refers to Asperger's Syndrome as mentioned by Kanner in 1943, which was linked to having a high IQ, this can be connected to how Charlie's mother tried to indicate that Charlie had Asperger's. The definition of autism has altered over the years such as Kanner terming it as a form of childhood schizophrenia. Wing a psychologist refers to Asperger's Syndrome and in 1994 it is seen as a separate disorder in the DSM 4th edition. This indicates how there is a constant change in the definition of autism thus the diagnosis and assessment of autism has been changing over the years too. In the last twenty years there have been developments in aiding children with autism to communicate. This demonstrates that children are more likely to receive more support today than in previous years as professionals knowledge of support systems for those with autism is constantly improving and advancing. Silberman refers to a surge in diagnoses in California however this can be due to a various number of factors due to more awareness of autism and more advances in intervention and support systems for autism being available and sought after. Rollens refers to there being a huge increase in autism. Funding can often prove difficult to obtain therefore indicates some hindrances to obtaining support for those with autism. Factors such as cost can often be considered when implementing interventions (Silberman 2001; Carlon et.al 2015).

In conclusion, it is not vital that Charlie receives a diagnosis of autism after reviewing outcomes (Russell et.al 2012). Overall it is important to perceive that early intervention is crucial for Charlie to ensure early improvement and to allow the intervention to be implemented and to take effect. However, it must also be considered that there is lack of evidence for the effectiveness of some interventions (Russell et.al 2012). Careful selection of the intervention based upon the needs of the specific child is often the factor that parents choose to decide upon an intervention (Russell et.al 2012; Carlon et. al 2015).

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